

27 Jul 2026 12:18:25 ET | 14 pages

Laopu Gold (6181.HK)

Severe miss in 2Q26

CITI'S TAKE

Laopu's preliminary 1H26 results implied 2Q26 NP was about 30% below Citi and market expectations. The severe earnings miss came from both topline and margin. Our 2026E-28E net profits, which are the seasonality-adjusted annualization of 2Q26, were lowered 17-22% accordingly on weaker sales and margin assumptions. We also expect a significant cut in street numbers and hence negative share price reaction in the near term. After forecast reset, we believe a potentially sequential sales improvement in SKP Mall's Aug promotion to be a re-rating opportunity. Buy with lower TP of HK\$507.

Implied 2Q26 results — According to mgmt, 1Q26 revenue and NP came in at the low end of the guidance range at Rmb16.5bn and Rmb3.6bn, respectively, weighed down by weaker-than-expected sales in March due to a pullback in gold prices. This implies 2Q26 revenue of Rmb3.3bn-3.95bn. Deducting SBC expenses of >Rmb40m (all incurred in 1Q26 per mgmt), reported NP is projected to be Rmb4.26bn-4.31bn in 1H26. This implies 2Q26 reported NP of Rmb660m-710m, with NPM down qoq to 18%-20% from 1Q26's 21.8%. Mgmt said the sequential NPM contraction in 2Q26 was driven by a higher sales mix of discounted products, steeper discounting (including gold coin gifting promotions), a lower online sales mix, and operating deleverage. Inventory rose as of end-Jun 2026 compared to Dec 2025 due to increased procurement in 2Q26, while operating cash flow turned positive in 1H26.

2H26E outlook — Mgmt said 2Q and 3Q represent the low season in the gold jewelry industry, while 1Q and 4Q are peak seasons, typically generating sales ~2x that of the low season (vs. industry average of 1.5x). Such seasonality implies 2H26E sales could reach 3x of 2Q26 level. On top of that, mgmt expect more attractive product pricing via incremental discount and new products carrying lower price per gram to stimulate sales. 2Q26 new products were limited to "test the waters" and, given positive customer feedback, major product rollouts are planned for 2H26E. We expect GPM in 2H26E to be lower than 2Q26's >45% due to these new launches, which anchor 43% GPM and additional 5% discount from top-tier membership, which can now be stacked with store promotions. That said, we expect potentially better operating leverage to offset lower GPM in 2H26E vs. 2Q26.

Earnings and valuation — We cut 2026E-28E NP 17-22% on lower revenue and margin, expecting Rmb6.4bn/5.1bn/5.9bn in 26E/27E (normalized earnings)/28E. Our TP is lowered to HK\$507.0 from HK\$659.0, based on unchanged 15x 27E P/E. Trading at 11.7x P/E and 6.4% yield in 27E, valuation remains undemanding to us.

Earnings Summary

Year to	Net Profit	Diluted EPS	EPS growth	P/E	P/B	ROE	Yield
31 Dec	(RmbM)	(Rmb)	(%)	(x)	(x)	(%)	(%)
2024A	1,502	9.655	253.4	35.5	14.7	55.3	1.9
2025A	5,029	29.285	203.3	11.7	5.4	67.0	6.3
2026E	6,455	36.596	25.0	9.4	4.4	52.0	8.0
2027E	5,200	29.480	-19.4	11.6	4.3	37.3	6.4
2028E	5,995	33.989	15.3	10.1	3.7	39.4	7.3

Source: Powered by dataCentral

Buy

Short-Term View: Downside

Price (27 Jul 26 16:10) HK\$396.40

Target price HK\$507.00↓
from HK\$659.00

Expected share price return 27.9%

Expected dividend yield 7.8%

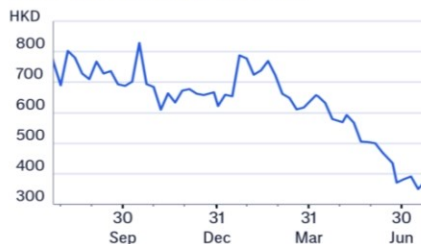
Expected total return 35.7%

Market Cap HK\$70,062M

US\$8,934M

Price Performance

(RIC: 6181.HK, BB: 6181 HK)



Tiffany Feng^{AC}

+852-2501-2759

tiffany.feng@citi.com

Xiaopo Wei, CFA

+852-2501-2472

xiaopo.wei@citi.com

Brian Cho

+852-2501-2712

brian.cho@citi.com

See Appendix A-1 for Analyst Certification, Important Disclosures and Research Analyst Affiliations.

6181.HK: Fiscal year end 31-Dec						Price: HK\$396.40; TP: HK\$507.00; Market Cap: HK\$70,062m; Recomm: Buy					
Profit & Loss (Rmbm)	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E	Valuation ratios	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E
Sales revenue	8,506	27,303	31,898	27,627	31,842	PE (x)	35.5	11.7	9.4	11.6	10.1
Cost of sales	-5,004	-17,029	-18,531	-15,939	-18,247	PB (x)	14.7	5.4	4.4	4.3	3.7
Gross profit	3,501	10,274	13,367	11,688	13,594	EV/EBITDA (x)	28.2	9.2	7.1	8.4	7.1
Gross Margin (%)	41.2	37.6	41.9	42.3	42.7	FCF yield (%)	-2.8	-12.4	9.5	12.4	7.8
EBITDA (Adj)	2,158	6,862	9,033	7,348	8,444	Dividend yield (%)	1.9	6.3	8.0	6.4	7.3
EBITDA Margin (Adj) (%)	25.4	25.1	28.3	26.6	26.5	Payout ratio (%)	66	74	74	74	74
Depreciation	-181	-339	-376	-385	-448	ROE (%)	54.2	64.8	51.6	36.7	38.8
Amortisation	0	0	0	0	0	Cashflow (Rmbm)	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E
EBIT (Adj)	1,977	6,523	8,657	6,963	7,995	EBITDA	2,158	6,862	9,033	7,348	8,444
EBIT Margin (Adj) (%)	23.2	23.9	27.1	25.2	25.1	Working capital	-3,038	-12,552	-960	2,085	-1,560
Net interest	-30	-139	-223	-224	-225	Other	-349	-1,158	-1,926	-1,589	-1,726
Associates	0	0	0	0	0	Operating cashflow	-1,228	-6,848	6,147	7,845	5,157
Non-Op/Except/Other Adj	0	0	0	0	0	Capex	-71	-145	-151	-98	-107
Pre-tax profit	1,947	6,384	8,434	6,739	7,770	Net acq/disposals	0	0	0	0	0
Tax	-473	-1,516	-2,024	-1,617	-1,865	Other	0	0	0	0	0
Extraord./Min.Int./Pref.div.	0	0	0	0	0	Investing cashflow	-71	-145	-151	-98	-107
Reported net profit	1,473	4,868	6,410	5,122	5,905	Dividends paid	0	-1,096	-3,800	-4,808	-3,841
Net Margin (%)	17.3	17.8	20.1	18.5	18.5	Financing cashflow	1,960	8,361	-4,308	-5,300	-4,378
Core NPAT	1,502	5,029	6,455	5,200	5,995	Net change in cash	663	1,335	1,688	2,447	672
Per share data	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E	Free cashflow to s/holders	-1,465	-7,261	5,711	7,478	4,738
Reported EPS (Rmb)	9.471	28.346	36.340	29.038	33.480						
Core EPS (Rmb)	9.655	29.285	36.596	29.480	33.989						
DPS (Rmb)	6.355	21.546	27.255	21.778	25.110						
CFPS (Rmb)	-7.898	-39.877	34.851	44.476	29.237						
FCFPS (Rmb)	-9.417	-42.280	32.380	42.397	26.864						
BVPS (Rmb)	23.284	62.902	77.952	80.176	92.387						
Wtd avg ord shares (m)	156	172	176	176	176						
Wtd avg diluted shares (m)	156	172	176	176	176						
Growth rates	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E						
Sales revenue (%)	167.5	221.0	16.8	-13.4	15.3						
EBIT (Adj) (%)	245.8	229.9	32.7	-19.6	14.8						
Core NPAT (%)	253.4	234.9	28.3	-19.4	15.3						
Core EPS (%)	253.4	203.3	25.0	-19.4	15.3						
Balance Sheet (Rmbm)	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E						
Cash & cash equiv.	733	2,068	3,606	6,053	6,725						
Accounts receivables	801	1,280	1,496	1,295	1,493						
Inventory	4,088	16,044	17,125	14,927	16,598						
Net fixed & other tangibles	198	304	370	350	326						
Goodwill & intangibles	305	399	539	564	594						
Financial & other assets	212	1,157	1,351	1,170	1,349						
Total assets	6,337	21,253	24,488	24,360	27,085						
Accounts payable	228	636	743	643	742						
Short-term debt	1,373	6,164	6,164	6,164	6,164						
Long-term debt	0	0	0	0	0						
Provisions & other liab	815	3,257	3,881	3,461	3,933						
Total liabilities	2,416	10,057	10,788	10,268	10,839						
Shareholders' equity	3,920	11,095	13,750	14,142	16,296						
Minority interests	0	0	0	0	0						
Total equity	3,920	11,095	13,750	14,142	16,296						
Net debt (Adj)	641	4,096	2,558	111	-561						
Net debt to equity (Adj) (%)	16.3	36.9	18.6	0.8	-3.4						

For definitions of the items in this table, please click [here](#).

Citi Consumer Research C-suite mgmt. meetings — (1) Eastroc Beverage (9980.HK /605499.SS) Board Secretary call at 3PM HKT on July 31 ([registration](#)); (2) YUM China (9987.HK/YUMC.N) CFO call on Jul 31 ([registration](#)); (3) UPC (0220.HK) CFO call on Aug 6 ([registration](#)); (4) WH Group (0288.HK) CEO & CFO call/meeting on Aug 12 ([registration](#)); (5) 361 Degrees (1361.HK) VP of the Board & CFO call on Aug 19 ([registration](#)); (6) H&H (1112.HK) Chairman, CEO & CFO meeting on Aug 26 ([registration](#))

Figure 1. Earnings revision

Rmb m	New			Old			Change		
	2026E	2027E	2028E	2026E	2027E	2028E	2026E	2027E	2028E
Revenue	31,898	27,627	31,842	33,633	28,346	32,416	-5.2%	-2.5%	-1.8%
Gross profit	13,367	11,688	13,594	15,282	13,572	15,634	-12.5%	-13.9%	-13.0%
Operating profit	8,657	6,963	7,995	10,337	8,817	10,137	-16.3%	-21.0%	-21.1%
Net profit	6,410	5,122	5,905	7,687	6,531	7,532	-16.6%	-21.6%	-21.6%
							ppts.	ppts.	ppts.
Gross margin	41.9%	42.3%	42.7%	45.4%	47.9%	48.2%	(3.5)	(5.6)	(5.5)
Operating margin	27.1%	25.2%	25.1%	30.7%	31.1%	31.3%	(3.6)	(5.9)	(6.2)
Net margin	20.1%	18.5%	18.5%	22.9%	23.0%	23.2%	(2.8)	(4.5)	(4.7)

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Source: Citi Research Estimates

Adding Downside 30-Day Short-Term View on Laopu Gold (6181.HK)

Direction: Downside
Duration: Within 30 Days
Category: Earnings

Laopu's preliminary 1H26 results implied 2Q26 NP was about 30% below Citi & market expectation. The severe earnings miss came from both topline and margin. We expect a significant cut in street numbers and hence negative share price reaction in the near term.

Bull/Bear: Laopu Gold (6181.HK)

HK\$ **557.00**
▲ 41% Upside

HK\$ **507.00**
▲ 28% Upside

HK\$ **360.00**
▼ 9.2% Downside



Spread 50pp
Current Price and expected returns (upside/downside) as of 27 Jul 2026

BULL Assumptions

- Revenue growth faster than expected
- EBIT margin higher than expected

BASE Assumptions

- Revenue to grow by 17% in 2026E
- EBIT margin to expand to 27.1% in 2026E

BEAR Assumptions

- Revenue growth slower than expected
- EBIT margin lower than expected

Laopu Gold

Company description

China jewelry retailer Laopu Gold has carved out a unique high-end product niche in “heritage gold,” combining modern designs and classic Chinese motifs, featuring at least two Chinese traditional handmade gold crafting techniques, often embedding diamonds and/or gemstones, with products sold in elegant boutiques styled like a traditional Chinese scholar’s study. Laopu’s key strengths include high ticket size (>Rmb50k on average), leading per-store sales (>Rmb500m), unique fixed-price model, superior profitability, and exquisite craftsmanship and product innovation in its “heritage gold” niche.

Investment strategy

We rate Laopu Gold shares as Buy. As price-sensitive customers are leaving, we believe Laopu now has a higher proportion of loyal customers who care less about the price premium. Thus, we expect future sales to have lower correlation to gold prices and further downside risk from gold price decline to be limited, which should improve earnings predictability. Although the customer mix shift led to earnings hiccups in the short term, this is likely already priced in, and we believe it warrants distinct brand positioning with matching audience, providing a more robust, sustainable business longer term, in our view.

Valuation

Our target price of HK\$507 is based on 15x 2027E P/E (normalized earnings) vs. global luxury peers’ 22x 2026E P/E. We apply ~30% valuation discount for Laopu’s to reflect its shorter brand history and track record period in the luxury industry. The implied 12x 2026E P/E is at the low end of global luxury peers.

Risks

Key downside risks that could impede the shares from reaching our target price include: 1) gold price volatility; 2) intense competition; 3) evolving consumer tastes and preferences; 4) consumption trade-down amid China’s soft economy; and 5) negative free cash flow amid expansion.

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Appendix A-1

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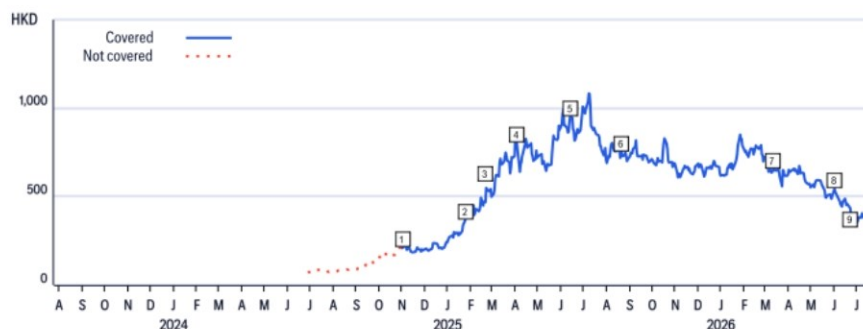
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IMPORTANT DISCLOSURES

Laopu Gold (6181.HK)

Ratings and Target Price History Fundamental Research

Analyst: Tiffany Feng



	Date	Rating	Target Price	Closing Price
1	01-Nov-24 07:39:40	*1H	*267.80	208.80
2	26-Jan-25 16:08:13	1H	*460.20	367.60
3	20-Feb-25 12:24:43	1H	*574.50	468.40

*Indicates Change

	Date	Rating	Target Price	Closing Price
4	02-Apr-25 00:19:31	*1	*979.00	799.00
5	13-Jun-25 16:32:37	1	*1,084.00	948.50
6	21-Aug-25 12:43:16	1	*1,119.00	751.00

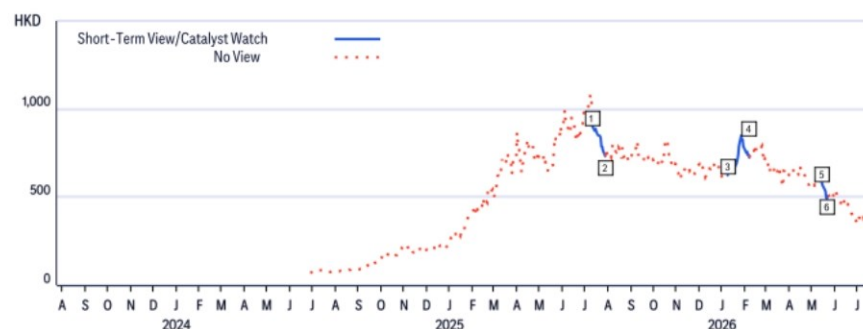
	Date	Rating	Target Price	Closing Price
7	11-Mar-26 03:33:29	1	*1,162.00	654.00
8	01-Jun-26 02:12:06	1	*700.00	543.00
9	22-Jun-26 10:32:19	1	*659.00	434.80

Rating/target price changes above reflect Eastern Time

Laopu Gold (6181.HK)

Short-Term View/Catalyst Watch Research

Analyst: Tiffany Feng



	Date	Action	Expected Direction	Duration	Closing Price
1	13-Jul-25 14:15:34	Add CW	Upside	30 Days	900.00
2	28-Jul-25 04:23:01	Remove CW	Upside	30 Days	733.00

CW - Catalyst Watch, STV - Short-Term View

	Date	Action	Expected Direction	Duration	Closing Price
3	08-Jan-26 06:51:39	Add CW	Upside	30 Days	624.50
4	06-Feb-26 12:29:14	Remove CW	Upside	30 Days	724.50

	Date	Action	Expected Direction	Duration	Closing Price
5	14-May-26 03:14:50	Add CW	Upside	30 Days	583.00
6	22-May-26 04:18:29	Remove CW	Upside	30 Days	505.50

Rating/target price changes above reflect Eastern Time

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Data current as of 01 Jul 2026	12 Month Rating			Catalyst Watch		
	Buy	Hold	Sell	Buy	Hold	Sell
Citi Research Global Fundamental Coverage (Neutral=Hold)	61%	32%	7%	36%	48%	16%
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